EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Seven Ways the Torah Speaks of Olam HaBa

Given Monday 29 September 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 9:3-4

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 9 (Olam HaBa, The World to Come), Chapters 3 and 4

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 29 September 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Case for Olam HaBa So Far

Rav Saadia's conception of **עולם הבא** is a newly created world in which **body and soul together** enjoy bliss for eternity. The first half of Essay 9 establishes that there is such a world at all:

- **Chapter 1:** six proofs **from logic**.
- **Chapter 2:** proofs **from the Torah**, followed by the question: if Olam HaBa is so logical, and can be proven from the Torah, why does the Torah not mention it explicitly? Whenever the Torah speaks about reward, it seems to be about this world. Saadia gave two answers, and over the last two shiurim the class went through **nine answers** in total, seven from the Rishonim and two from later thinkers.

Tonight, moving quickly, the Rabbi covered two chapters:

- **Chapter 3:** not proofs, but **seven categories**, seven different ways in which the Torah and Tanach refer to Olam HaBa.
- **Chapter 4:** a few of the very many **statements of Chazal** about Olam HaBa.

From Chapter 5 to the end of the essay, Saadia goes into "the meat" of what Olam HaBa is: what happens there, where and when it is, whether there is time, whether there are still mitzvot. That would begin after Sukkot.

The shiur was given in the Aseret Yemei Teshuvah, two days before Yom Kippur, and started at 5:30 because of the early Minchah time. Several of the Rabbi's comments tied the chapter to the prayers of the season.

Chapter 3: Seven Categories

Saadia opens: having brought the proofs from the Torah in the previous chapter, he will now add **seven categories**. Each has a source in the Torah and is then followed up in Nevi'im and Ketuvim.

Category 1: Life and death

The Torah calls Olam HaBa **חיים**, life, and calls the lot of those who do not merit it **מות**, death.

אשר יעשה אתם האדם וחי בהם (Vayikra 18:5)

Which a person shall do and live by them.

הנפש החטאת היא תמות (Yechezkel 18:4)

The soul that sins, it shall die.

Saadia reads "and live by them" as life in the World to Come. His reasoning: in this world, **the tzaddik and the rasha seem to be equal**. So when the Tanach promises life for doing the mitzvot, it cannot mean life in this world. It must mean the life of Olam HaBa. "He takes two questions and balances them off each other."

He brings many verses:

כי מצאי מצא חיים... כל משנאי אהבו מות (Mishlei 8:35-36): whoever finds me finds life; all who hate me love death.

ארח חיים למעלה למשכיל למען סור משאול מטה (Mishlei 15:24): the path of life goes upward for the wise, to turn away from the grave below.

דרכי שאול ביתה (Mishlei 7:27): her house is the way to the grave.

לולא האמנתי לראות בטוב ה' בארץ חיים (Tehillim 27:13), which we say now, this month." The "land" of life" is clearly Olam HaBa.

כי לא תעזב נפשי לשאול לא תתן חסידך לראות שחת. תודיעני ארח חיים (Tehillim 16:10-11): You will not abandon my soul to the grave... You will make known to me the path of life.

Why we say Psalm 16 at a funeral

The Rabbi pointed out that **Tehillim 16, מכתם לדוד**, is recited at a levayah because of this very pasuk. It is such a strong proof: David HaMelech says, don't leave me in the grave, show me the path of life. "What do you mean? You're dead, you're in the grave. That's the point." Even after I die and lie in the grave, show me the real life, the life of Olam HaBa. At a funeral we are saying that the person has died physically, but please God he will have the path of life for the future.

Why "life" has no adjective in the Amidah

A digression for the season. In the Aseret Yemei Teshuvah we add four lines to the Amidah:

Berachah	Addition	Wording
1	**זכרנו לחיים**	life, unqualified
2	**מי כמוך... זוכר יצוריו לחיים ברחמים**	life, unqualified
3rd from end	**וכתוב לחיים טובים כל בני בריתך**	**good** life
Last	**בספר חיים ברכה ושלום**	life of blessing and peace

Two questions:

1. Why is it just "life" in the first two, while at the end we must add adjectives?

2. How can we ask for anything in the first three berachot, which are meant only for praise and recognition, not requests?

"There's much more to this, but in short": **חיים without an adjective means the real life**, the life of Olam HaBa. That needs no qualification. If you have to put an adjective on life, it is not Olam HaBa.

The judgment of Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur is certainly about the coming year. But, the Rabbi said, there is also a judgment of **what kind of life we will live** in the coming year: will it be a life of Olam HaBa? Tosafot already writes that the judgment of Rosh Hashanah concerns **חיי עולם הבא**. Why would you need a judgment every year on your Olam HaBa, after 120? Because it means **the life of Olam HaBa in this world**.

People can have parnassah, health, children, even happiness, "great lives. But they're not living a life of spiritual yearning, a life where they're able to grow, to fulfil their potential, to become the best version of themselves. That's חיים. That's זכרנו לחיים." And that can be asked for in the opening berachot, because it is part of recognising Hashem: a life lived with Hashem. "Living the year where I am present, I am aware, I am cognisant of HaKadosh Baruch Hu's presence in my life." Only at the end come the physical things: good life, health, blessing, peace, money.

A question: death or karet?

A participant asked: for the Rambam, the opposite of Olam HaBa is **karet**, being cut off, and most people will reach Olam HaBa at some level of closeness to Hashem. Saadia seems to speak of plain death.

The Rabbi called it "a very excellent point." From these verses alone one could read it either way, but she was right: **Saadia does not see punishment the way the Rambam does**. For the Rambam, the Rabbi said, punishment is always "in inverted commas." There is no punishment, only consequences, and the greatest is karet. For Saadia, punishments are punishments **in the literal sense**, and he will describe them in quite graphic terms in a later chapter. Saadia himself will then ask why a merciful God would need to do this. The Rambam never has that question, because for him it is about consequences, not punishment.

Category 2: Good stored away

The Tanach tells us that **good is stored away for the deeds of the righteous, and bad held back for the wicked**.

זכר צדיק לברכה ושם רשעים ירקב (Mishlei 10:7). The simple meaning is what we say when a righteous person dies: the memory of the righteous is a blessing, and the name of the wicked should rot. Saadia reads it as storing: the righteous will be remembered by Hashem for blessing, i.e. blessing is kept for them in the future, and rot is kept for the wicked.

זכרה לי אלהי לטובה (Nechemiah 5:19): remember me, my God, for good.

זכרה אלהי לטוביה ולסנבלט כמעשיו אלה (Nechemiah 6:14): Tobiah and Sanballat were the officials who tried to stop Nechemiah rebuilding. Remember their deeds.

וצדקה תהיה לנו (Devarim 6:25): it will be stored up as good for us.

והלך לפניך צדקך כבוד ה' יאספך (Yeshayahu 58:8): your righteousness will walk before you. Another verse said at funerals.

Tzedakah is not charity

On **וצדקה תהיה לנו** the Rabbi recalled a point Rabbi Sacks always made: the Torah's word for justice and for charity is the same. "Charity is the wrong translation of צדקה." In English, charity means going above and beyond, something voluntary that marks an extra kind person. The Torah does not see it like that. "צדקה, it's צדק, you have to give it." If you make 100 pounds, Hashem says 90 are yours, "10 pounds, it's צדק, it's just. It's not charity, it's an obligation."

Category 3: The books

The Tanach speaks of Hashem having **books** in which the deeds of the righteous and the wicked are written. Saadia has already given a whole essay on the incorporeality of God, so obviously there are no literal books, but the concept is that everything is recorded.

"Of course that's what these whole ten days are about." The righteous were signed already on Rosh Hashanah; most of us are beinonim waiting until Yom Kippur. Those are the books of the year. But there are also books **for eternity**.

מחני נא מספרך אשר כתבת (Shemot 32:32)

Erase me, please, from Your book which You have written.

Ask most people what Moshe meant after the golden calf, and they will say: erase me from the Torah. They will tell you the famous idea that **Tetzaveh**, the parashah before Ki Tisa, is the only parashah from Moshe's birth onward without his name. That is the midrashic reading, and the Gemara does explain it as the Torah. But the simple meaning, according to the Rishonim, is different. The Ramban says **the book of life**, and Saadia says something similar, **the book of the righteous**. If You do not accept my prayer, I do not want to be counted among Your tzaddikim. Erase me from the books where You write who will have Olam HaBa.

More verses:

ימחו מספר חיים (Tehillim 69:29): let them be erased from the book of life.

ויכתב ספר זכרון לפניו ליראי ה' ולחשבי שמו (Malachi 3:16): a book of remembrance was written before Him, for those who fear God and value His name.

הנה כתובה לפני (Yeshayahu 65:6): behold, it is written before Me.

Category 4: A tribunal

Hashem has a **מעמד**, a setting or tribunal, at which He repays every deed, good and bad.

הלוא אם תיטיב שאת ואם לא תיטיב לפתח חטאת רבץ (Bereishit 4:7)

If you improve, you will be uplifted; and if you do not improve, sin crouches at the door.

The **Targum Onkelos**, followed by the sages, reads this as: if you do not improve, your sin is waiting for you **at the entrance of the tribunal**, the day of judgment.

את הצדיק ואת הרשע ישפט האלהים כי עת לכל חפץ ועל כל המעשה שם (Kohelet 3:17): God will judge the righteous and the wicked, for there is a time for everything, and for every deed **there**. "What does 'there' mean?" There is a beit din to come.

שם פחדו פחד (Tehillim 14:5): there they were very afraid.

שם נפלו פעלי און (Tehillim 36:13): there the evildoers fell.

- And the verse about crying out there and not being answered.

On that last idea the Rabbi said: "You can cry now as much as you want. Hashem listens to our prayers now." But there, you see what you have done and the consequences of everything in your life. "You're going to cry there, but there's no answer anymore. That's it. This is the time."

Category 5: Hashem judges justly

The Tanach stresses that Hashem **judges with justice**. If so, Saadia argues, there must be an Olam HaBa, because "this world, whether we like it or not, at least to our eyes, doesn't always seem to be just." The real justice must come in the next.

הצור תמים פעלו כי כל דרכיו משפט אל אמונה ואין עול צדיק וישר הוא (Devarim 32:4)

The Rock, His work is perfect, for all His ways are just; a faithful God without iniquity, righteous and upright is He.

This was from that week's parashah, Ha'azinu, read that morning. It too is said at a funeral: someone has died, it seems unfair, and we declare that His ways are just. There will be a place where justice is done.

More verses: **וצדיק באמונתו יחיה** (Chavakuk 2:4); **צדיק כתמר יפרח** (Tehillim 92:13); **והוא ישפט תבל בצדק** (Tehillim 9:9); **כי נכח עיני ה' דרכי איש** (Mishlei 5:21); **כי את כל מעשה האלהים יבא במשפט** (Kohelet 12:14).

A gematria for Rosh Hashanah

The Rabbi shared a gematria he heard from **Jeremy Benjamin** a few years earlier and checked himself:

למשפטיך עמדו היום כי הכל עבדיך (Tehillim 119:91)

For Your judgments they stand today, for all are Your servants.

The simple meaning is the future judgment. But the gematria of the verse equals **ראש השנה**, the day "they stood today" for judgment. "Work it out afterwards."

He added that he is "not a huge fan of gematriot." As Pirkei Avot says, they are **פרפראות לחכמה**, the gravy for wisdom. "When you have an idea, then you can add a gematria to add gravy to the meat. But you can't make an idea from a gematria. But here, it's so perfect."

Category 6: A day of retribution

Close to Category 4, but here the Tanach speaks of **a set day** for repayment.

קרוב יום ה' הגדול קרוב ומהר מאד... יום עברה היום ההוא... והצרתי לאדם והלכו כעורים (Tzefaniah 1:14-17)

The great day of Hashem is near, near and hastening... a day of wrath is that day... I will bring distress on people and they will walk like the blind.

התקוששו וקושו... בטרם לדת חק (Tzefaniah 2:1-2)

Gather yourselves together... before the decree is born.

Category 7: "Good"

Finally, the Tanach calls the reward of Olam HaBa **טוב**, good, and withholds it from the wicked.

למען ייטב להם ולבניהם לעולם (Devarim 5:26): that it may be good for them and their children **forever**.

מה רב טובך אשר צפנת ליראיך (Tehillim 31:20): how great is Your goodness that You have stored away for those who fear You.

כי גם יודע אני אשר יהיה טוב ליראי האלהים אשר ייראו מלפניו. וטוב לא יהיה לרשע (Kohelet 8:12-13): I know it will be good for those who fear God... and it will not be good for the wicked.

Saadia's conclusion: let reason decide the reading

Someone might try to interpret all these verses differently and say they are not about Olam HaBa. Saadia replies: that is not so, **because reason requires reward in another world**, as Chapter 1 showed. And when an interpretation agrees with what reason testifies to be true, that is the interpretation you hold to.

Summary of Chapter 3

#	How the Tanach describes Olam HaBa
1	**Life**, with its opposite **death**
2	Good **stored away** for the righteous, bad for the wicked
3	**Books** in which all deeds are written
4	A **tribunal** where everything is judged
5	Hashem **judges justly**, which can only be fully true in Olam HaBa
6	A **day of retribution**
7	It is called **good**, and its opposite not good

So Chapter 1 gave proofs from logic, and Chapters 2 and 3 from Scripture: Chapter 2 proofs, Chapter 3 the categories of how Scripture refers to Olam HaBa.

Chapter 4: The Testimony of Tradition

Saadia now turns to **הקבלה**, the tradition of Chazal. The material is "too broad to write it all," so he gives the headlines: **five proofs**.

Proof 1: The corridor and the palace

Our sages received from the prophets that this world, compared to Olam HaBa, is like **a corridor before a royal palace**. A person must prepare himself as is fitting before entering the king's palace.

העולם הזה דומה לפרוזדור בפני העולם הבא, התקן עצמך בפרוזדור כדי שתכנס לטרקלין (Avot 4:16)

This world is like a corridor before the World to Come. Prepare yourself in the corridor so that you may enter the banquet hall.

When you enter a wedding or a palace, you touch yourself up in the entrance so you look your best. If you did not prepare there, "you're going to walk in, you're going to look terrible." So this world is the vestibule, and Olam HaBa is the real thing.

Proof 2: One hour here, one hour there

The sages also said that one hour of teshuvah in this world is worth more than all the life of Olam HaBa, in which there is no teshuvah. Whatever is written on the soul in this world cannot be erased once a person has died. And one hour of rest in Olam HaBa is better than all the life of this world.

> **יפה שעה אחת בתשובה ומעשים טובים בעולם הזה מכל חיי העולם הבא, ויפה שעה אחת של קורת רוח בעולם הבא מכל חיי העולם הזה** (Avot 4:17)

Better one hour of teshuvah and good deeds in this world than all the life of the World to Come; and better one hour of tranquillity in the World to Come than all the life of this world.

"A lot of ink has been spilt on this Mishnah." The Rabbi noted that it is said by **Rabbi Yaakov**, the same Rabbi Yaakov who says in Kiddushin that **שכר מצוה בהאי עלמא ליכא**, there is no reward for mitzvot in this world.

The obvious question: the first half says one hour here is better than all of Olam HaBa, and the second half says one hour there is better than all of this world. "So which one is it? Make your mind up."

The answer is that they speak about two different things. **This world is for deeds; Olam HaBa is for reward and satisfaction.**

- **Deeds:** one moment of good deeds here is worth more than all of Olam HaBa, because there you can no longer do good deeds. "This is the end." So we must make the most of our deeds now.
- **Reward:** one moment of satisfaction in the next world is greater than everything in this one.

"Of course, we can't live with that perspective always, everything's about the next world. We are at the end of the day a this-world religion. We do care about this world." But we always need the bigger picture of eternity in front of us.

Proof 3: No eating or drinking

The sages taught that the life of Olam HaBa is like **light**, with nothing of this world in it, only the reward of the righteous in the glory of the Creator:

> **העולם הבא אין בו לא אכילה ולא שתיה ולא פריה ורביה ולא משא ומתן... אלא צדיקים יושבין ועטרותיהם בראשיהם ונהנין מזיו השכינה** (Berachot 17a)

In the World to Come there is no eating, no drinking, no procreation, no business... only the righteous sitting with their crowns on their heads, enjoying the radiance of the Shechinah.

Saadia promises to explain in the coming chapters what this pleasure is. "Saadia is quite brave in trying to explain what Olam HaBa is," the Rabbi said. The Rambam, as the class had learned, backed off: I can only tell you it is unfathomable. Saadia tries quite hard to explain it.

Proof 4: Those who have no share

The sages held this belief so strongly that they taught that whoever denies Olam HaBa, or the giving of the Torah, or does not accept the tradition, has no share in Olam HaBa for all his good deeds.

> **ואלו שאין להם חלק לעולם הבא: האומר אין תחיית המתים, ואין תורה מן השמים, ואפיקורס** (Sanhedrin 10:1)

These have no share in the World to Come: one who says there is no resurrection of the dead, one who says the Torah is not from Heaven, and the apikores.

The **apikores**, the Rabbi explained, is one who disgraces the Chachamim and does not accept the rabbinic tradition.

The Rabbi pointed out that **this proof works for Saadia but not for the Rambam**. For Saadia, Olam HaBa is body and soul together, so resurrection is the beginning of Olam HaBa, and denying techiyat hametim is denying Olam HaBa. For the Rambam, techiyat hametim belongs to this world, and Olam HaBa is the soul alone. The Rambam would of course agree that one must believe in Olam HaBa, but this particular proof depends on Saadia's view.

The same Mishnah lists those who caused the many to sin:

שלשה מלכים וארבעה הדיוטות אין להם חלק לעולם הבא (Sanhedrin 10:2)

The three kings are **Yerovam, Achav and Menasheh**; the four commoners are **Bilam, Doeg, Achitofel and Gechazi**. All of them led others astray. Either way, the sages clearly believed in Olam HaBa.

Proof 5: The Targum

Finally, the **Targum**, which the Rabbi dated to around the first or second century, "so it's 2,000 years old," speaks of Olam HaBa. Two examples come from **Vezot HaBerachah**, the parashah coming up:

- On **ויתא ראשי עם** (Devarim 33:21), about Moshe, "he came at the head of the people," Onkelos translates **ועל ונפק בריש עמא**, he will go out and come in at the head of the people. Moshe will be our leader **even in Olam HaBa**.
- On **יחי ראובן ואל ימת** (Devarim 33:6), "may Reuven live and not die," Onkelos translates: **יחי ראובן בחיי עלמא ומותא תנינא לא ימות**, may Reuven live in eternal life and not die **the second death**.

And in the Targum of the Prophets there is more than anyone could count.

Summary of Chapter 4

1. This world is a **corridor** before Olam HaBa.
2. One hour of **satisfaction** in Olam HaBa outweighs all of this world (and one hour of good deeds here outweighs all of the next).
3. Olam HaBa has **no eating or drinking**, only the radiance of the Shechinah.
4. The Mishnah lists those who have **no share** in Olam HaBa.
5. The **Targumim** speak of Olam HaBa in many places.

The End of Part One

Saadia concludes: having explained the World to Come from **reason** (Chapter 1), **Scripture** (Chapters 2 and 3) and **tradition** (Chapter 4), we can say that we all agree on it, clearly and explicitly.

That completes the first half of the essay. From Chapter 5 to the end, Saadia turns to the nature of Olam HaBa and asks many questions: What is the nature of reward and punishment? Where will it be? Will there be time? Will we be able to see each other? Will there still be service of

Hashem? Will we be able to choose? He goes through them one by one over the coming chapters.

The next Monday shiur would be in three weeks, after Sukkot and Shemini Atzeret, with no Tuesday shiur the next night because of Yom Kippur. The Rabbi reminded everyone that while Minchah is early the shiur starts earlier, returning to the usual time when the clocks change.

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